I was just over a month into my new job as governor of the Reserve Bank of India but I was not new to the IMF and World Bank meetings which are held twice a year—the spring meetings in April and the annual meetings in September or October. As a mid-level official in the finance ministry in the late ’80s, it was my task to prepare briefs to the finance minister and the finance secretary who would go for these meetings. As finance secretary myself since early 2007, I had attended these meetings as a regular delegate. The G20 was a later innovation but I was a little familiar with the set-up, having attended a couple of G20 meetings earlier that year in my capacity as the finance secretary; however, those were meetings of deputies (finance secretaries and deputy governors). This meeting, of finance ministers and governors, was a notch higher in the hierarchy. It was also, in the words of the convenors, ‘an extraordinary meeting to discuss an extraordinary situation’.

I was quite irritated by this late request to be a lead speaker. I was fatigued and jet-lagged, and my schedule for the day was clogged with meetings and appointments with a lot of stakeholders who typically gather in Washington during the week of these Fund–Bank meetings—possibly wanting to get a measure of this unknown guy who had landed up as the governor of RBI. With virtually little time and even less mind space to organize my thoughts, my first impulse was to decline the request. But then ego came in the way. I was, by all accounts, a greenhorn governor, unknown to most ministers and governors; yet they chose to ask me to give the Asian perspective on what was turning out to be a ferocious crisis. I had to take on the challenge! My experienced support staff, efficient as they always were, cancelled a couple of appointments to slot a half hour to tutor me for the meeting.

## An Anxious G20

Since the mid-1990s, the biannual Fund–Bank meetings have also become a high-profile venue for protests spanning a wide array of disparate causes—repressive aid conditionalities, trade imperialism, climate change, gender